

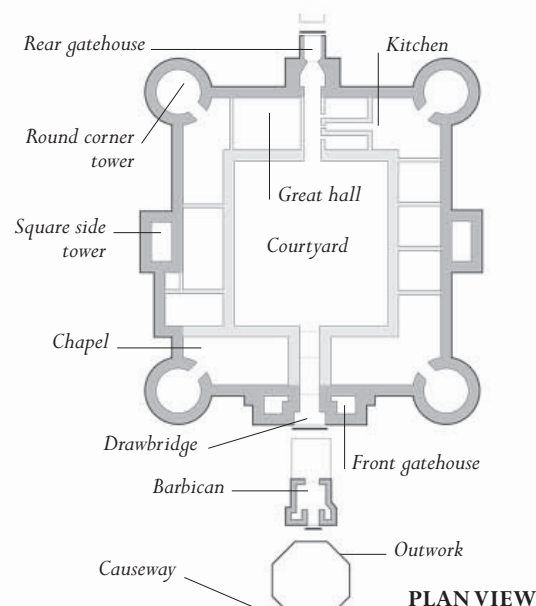
MEDIEVAL FORTIFICATION

BODIAM CASTLE

Europe's larger medieval castles were military strongholds and centres of administration. Smaller castles, such as Bodiam in southern England, were the homes of wealthy knights, built in martial styles.

Early European castles were built of wood and earth. With the adoption of stone as a construction material in the 11th century, castles became more expensive to build, but also longer lasting and more immune to fire and rot. The first stone castles had a central tower, or "keep", encircled by a defensive wall. By the time Sir Edward Dallingridge built Bodiam in 1385, towers had been integrated into the walls and the gatehouse had become the most strongly defended part of the castle.

A castle was a statement of the owner's wealth, power, and prestige, but it was also skilfully designed to give its occupants the best chance of fending off an enemy. Its walls and towers thus had to be resistant to stone-throwing siege engines and difficult for tunnel-digging engineers to undermine. However, the increasing use of gunpowder and cannon in the 15th century, eventually made the stone walls of the medieval castle obsolete, for they could not withstand battering by powerful artillery.



PLAN VIEW

▲ CASTLE LAYOUT

Built around a courtyard, Bodiam Castle had circular towers at each corner, square towers on each side, and fortified gatehouses at the front and the back.

MAIN ENTRANCE



▲ MAIN GATE

A potential weak point, vulnerable to a battering ram, the gate could be protected by lowering the iron portcullis.



▲ SHIELDS OVER MAIN GATE

Heraldic shields were meant to impress visitors. The family coat of arms identified the owner and his status in the feudal order.

► SURROUNDED BY WATER

The moat forced attackers to approach the castle by the causeway at the front or a wooden bridge at the rear. It is also an impressive ornamental work that makes the castle appear larger than it really is.

